

A Ridiculously Fascinating Journey

You're at your desk and fire a printout. Data on your hard disk, stored as tiny magnetic polarisations that a head some nanometres above them picks up, is sent over some wires as tiny variations in voltage to the printer. This, now, picks the data up into its RAM; what happens is, the voltage variations in the wire get converted into voltage changes in some transistors a few microns large. Then the print head: etc. etc. ... you get the idea. All this is routine, but it's insanely complex. Just how did we get to where we are? Sitting at a desk and firing a print, from using gas lamps at night just a few hundred years ago?

Edison invented the bulb, Baird (this is disputable) brought in the TV, and more, but here we're interested in just how the information age was shaped.

There are many ways to view it. You can think about it as inventors and innovators with their creations; you can think about it as pieces in a puzzle; you can think about it as fierce competition in capitalism-driven countries (where most of all this happened). The fact is, we have chosen this path. And what's happened along the journey is what we bring you here in this book.

We first talk about prehistoric times leading up to 1949, clubbing it all into one chapter, then start off with the decades: the 50s, the 60s, and so on up to the 00s (if you like to call it that). We then look at what prominent (and not-so-prominent but nevertheless important) figureheads in tech have to say about the future of this journey we're dwelling on.

Make your own trends: we see a gradual shift from innovation to building upon existing ideas. Derive your own insights: we see that Microsoft's supremacy has been much dictated by fate (or so it would seem). Take your pleasure in this year-wise presentation of the facts. It's a massive build-up, this—from the adding of numbers to the precise control of the extra-planetary behaviour of electrons.